it, but to the army and the nation at large as well. It would amount to professional sacrilege if the name of a major exercise was decided nonchalantly, without relevance to the aforementioned aspects, and more so on the whims and fancies of the commander concerned, howsoever humorous his intentions might have been. In my reckoning, 'Mayhem' did not gel as a name for an exercise with troops at a corps level. What motivation or inspiration would the officers and soldiers draw out of it? Though these manoeuvres were to be held in the month of May, and there is always an element of confusion in every exercise, yet it did not justify being called Exercise Mayhem or Summer Madness.

Once the initial formalities and visits were over, I sought a meeting with the army commander, Lieutenant General Pankaj Joshi, to discuss issues relating to operational tasks, training and administration and the forthcoming exercise. A seasoned soldier, the GOC-in-C welcomed me and we had a pleasant conversation. I also discussed the exercise with him and he approved the overall strategic theme, aim, scope and the lessons to be brought out. Finally, I told him I would like to change the name of the exercise to Poorna Vijay. He agreed.

While flying in the Cheetah helicopter (an indigenous version of the French Alouette) from Mathura to Lucknow for this meeting, I had a brush with death. Brigadier Jasbir Lidder, an outstanding professional, was my brigadier general staff. The lanky officer wanted to explain something on the map. In the process of opening the mapsheet, he spread his legs and stamped his boot on the collective lever of the chopper. There was a cracking sound and the chopper went down with a jerk. The pilot, who had momentarily taken his hand off the collective when this happened, quickly grabbed the lever and arrested the fall. For a moment I thought we were gone!

In my long military career, I was often witness to unprofessional higher commanders trashing an exercise while it was being conducted, and that too in the presence of junior officers and men. This could only happen if the big boss hadn't bothered to give clear directions regarding what the exercise ought to achieve, and